

Pink Bug Turns Green to Hide Like a Leaf!

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What if you could change color to match your surroundings? A bug called a **katydid** can do just that! Scientists in Panama found a bright pink **katydid** a type of grasshopper-like insect. But here's the surprise: in less than two weeks, it turned completely green. The researchers think this is a clever trick to hide from **predators**. In the rainforest, many new leaves are pink or red when they first grow. Then they slowly turn green. So a pink **katydid** blends in with the young leaves, and a green one matches the older leaves. It's like wearing a disguise that changes with the seasons! Dr. Benito Wainwright, who led the study, said, "Finding this individual was a genuine surprise. Rather than a bizarre **genetic quirk**, this may actually be a finely tuned **survival strategy**." The team kept the insect for 30 days and took photos every day. The pink faded after four days, and by day eleven, it was fully green. Before this, scientists thought pink **katydids** were rare **mutants** that couldn't survive well. But this discovery shows they might be masters of **camouflage**. Dr. Matt Greenwell added, "You would think that a bright pink insect in a mostly green forest would stand out to **predators** like a worker in a high-vis jacket. But it's a remarkable example of **camouflage** in action." So next time you see a pink leaf, look closely a **katydid** might be hiding there!

Word Treasure

katydid -- A type of insect related to grasshoppers, with long legs and a body that looks like leaves.

predators -- Animals that hunt and eat other animals.

mutants -- Living things that have a change in their genes, which can make them look different from others of their kind.

camouflage -- Colors or patterns on an animal's body that help it blend into its surroundings.

genetic quirk -- An unusual trait caused by a random change in genes, often rare.

survival strategy -- A behavior or feature that helps an animal stay alive and avoid danger.

Background you need

Panama (a country in Central America) is home to dense rainforests where many leaves start pink or red before turning green.

Katydid's are masters of disguise, and scientists had long thought that a pink katydid was a rare mistake that would quickly be eaten.

Dr. Benito Wainwright (a biologist who studies insect behavior) and his team proved that the color change is actually a clever hiding trick tied to the life of the leaves.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists led by Dr. Benito Wainwright.

WHAT: They found a bright pink katydid that changed color to green in just eleven days.

WHERE: In a rainforest in Panama.

WHY: The insect's color matches young pink leaves, then mimics older green leaves, helping it hide from predators all through the leaf's life.

Why it matters

This shows that even a tiny bug can have an amazing built-in costume change, reminding us that nature has clever solutions we are only beginning to understand.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of insect is the katydid?

- ☐ (A) A butterfly
- ☐ (B) A grasshopper-like insect
- ☐ (C) A beetle
- ☐ (D) A spider

2. What color was the katydid when scientists first found it?

- ☐ (A) Green
- ☐ (B) Blue
- ☐ (C) Bright pink
- ☐ (D) Brown

3. How long did it take for the pink katydid to become fully green?

- ☐ (A) One day
- ☐ (B) Four days
- ☐ (C) Eleven days
- ☐ (D) Thirty days

4. Why might a pink katydid be good at hiding in the rainforest?

- ☐ (A) It matches the color of flowers
- ☐ (B) Young leaves are often pink or red
- ☐ (C) It scares predators with bright colors
- ☐ (D) It's always pink

5. Who is the lead scientist in this discovery?

- ☐ (A) Chris Williams
- ☐ (B) Dr. Benito Wainwright
- ☐ (C) Michael Yu Wang
- ☐ (D) Dr. Matt Greenwell

6. What comparison did Dr. Matt Greenwell use to describe a bright pink insect in a green forest?

- ☐ (A) Like a needle in a haystack
- ☐ (B) Like a worker in a high-vis jacket
- ☐ (C) Like a fish out of water
- ☐ (D) Like a star in the sky

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **The research team:** They believe this is a finely tuned survival strategy, showing how katydids perfectly match their leafy homes at every stage.
2. **Earlier scientists:** Before this discovery, many thought pink katydids were doomed mutants because their bright color would make them stand out to predators.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):